Seasonal herding in the Himachal hills, 1881 to 1961

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Research question

How did the seasonal movement of flocks and herds between high summer pastures and low winter grazing shape life in the Himachal hills between 1881 and 1961, and who controlled and profited from it? As rule over the hills, control of the pastures, roads, and trade changed across the period, did the herding cycle persist as an adaptation to mountain and season, or did the ownership of flocks, pastures, and shepherds' labour reshape it?

Background

Herders in the Himachal hills practise transhumance, moving their animals between high summer pastures and low winter grazing while keeping a fixed home and fields. The Gaddis of Brahmaur and the Kinnauras of the upper Sutlej move sheep and goats in this way, and the Gujjars move buffaloes. The 1881 census, H. A. Rose's *Glossary* of 1911, and the 1961 village surveys, all describe the Gaddis taking their flocks down to Kangra for the winter. Rose mentions that the flocks move down in October and November, and return in April and May. In 1961, the flocks of Kanum, on the upper Sutlej, spend the months from October to April in the lower hills. The Gujjars of Maingal take their buffaloes to higher pastures in May and return in September.

Until about 1950, the Raja of Chamba owned all grazing rights and auctioned the right to collect grazing fees, usually to a Gaddi. By 1961, the Forest Department issued permits that fixed how many animals each shepherd could graze. The 1961 census survey of Brahmaur records that Brahmans and Rajputs owned most of its sheep and goats.

Approach

Our study will cover the 1961 village surveys of Brahmaur, Chitrari, Devi-Kothi, and Maingal in Chamba; Kanum, Kothi, and Nachar in Kinnaur; Shakrori in Mahasu; Bir in Mandi; and Tandi in Lahaul. In our analysis, we will use both an Annales and a Marxist reading of the sources.

For the Annales reading, we will use Fernand Braudel's three scales of historical time, the *longue durée*, the conjuncture, and the event. In the *longue durée*, we will look at how relief, climate, rivers, forests, and pasture shape the herding cycle and daily life in the hills. We will also use Marc Bloch's comparative method. First, we will compare how the 1881 census, Rose's *Glossary*, and the 1961 village surveys describe the herding cycle. Second, we will compare villages high in the mountains whose families keep large flocks, such as Brahmaur, with villages in the lower hills that buy animals from passing herders, such as Bir. Third, we will compare the herding families of Brahmaur with the settled farmers of Devi-Kothi, who send their animals to the high pastures with hired graziers. Fourth, we will compare the Ravi valley, where the Raja of Chamba held the grazing rights and the flocks spent the winter in Kangra, with the upper Sutlej, where the pastures were common land and the flocks also carried trade to Tibet. To support this reading, we will try to map the routes, passes, and pastures that the village surveys and W. H. Newell's study of the Gaddis describe, using maps from the period such as the 1961 Punjab Census Atlas. We will also chart the herding calendar from the seasonal accounts in the surveys.

For the Marxist reading, we will use class analysis and the dialectic. With class analysis, we will ask who owned the means of production, in this case the flocks and the pastures, who performed the labour of herding, and by what means the owners took a share of its product, whether as rent, grazing fees, revenue, or interest. The dialectic explains historical change through contradiction, the conflict between opposed forces within one arrangement, which produces a new arrangement. We will apply both to each conjuncture identified in the Annales reading. These include the holding of Gaddi land in both British Kangra and Chamba State in 1881, the Raja's ownership of grazing rights and his auction of fee collection until about 1950, the Forest Department's grazing permits, and the road and building work until 1961. To support this reading, we will compile the tables of livestock and debt by caste and household in the village surveys, and compare the grazing fees under the Raja with the fees the Forest Department charged.